

A Giant Heat Dome Is Baking the World Cup -- Here's How Players and Fans Are Staying Safe

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Imagine standing in an oven while trying to kick a soccer ball. That's what players at the 2026 World Cup are dealing with right now. A huge **heat dome** a bubble of super-hot air is sitting over the U.S. and Canada. In some cities, it feels like 110 degrees Fahrenheit outside! That's hotter than a hot tub.

Thursday's game in Toronto between Portugal and Croatia will be extra toasty. The stadium doesn't have a full roof, so about 43,000 fans will be baking in the sun. In Kansas City on Friday, Colombia vs. Ghana will play under an **extreme heat warning**. The heat index could hit 110°F. Even walking to the stadium is risky. In Dallas, the sidewalk can get as hot as 122°F hot enough to fry an egg!

FIFA, the group that runs the World Cup, is trying to help. Every game now has two **mandatory** water breaks, one in each half. Players can also be swapped out up to five times. Some stadiums, like in Atlanta and Houston, have roofs and air conditioning. But others, like Philadelphia and Kansas City, don't. Fans there will rely on **misting stations** and shade tents.

Heat can be dangerous. It can make players dizzy, cramp up, or even cause **heat stroke**, which is very serious. The heat also changes how the game is played players run slower to save energy. **FIFA** says they planned the schedule to avoid the hottest times, but this week is still a scorcher. So if you're watching, remember: stay hydrated, just like the pros!

Word Treasure

heat dome -- A giant bubble of hot air trapped over an area.

mandatory -- Something that must be done, no choice.

FIFA -- The organization that runs the World Cup.

heat stroke -- A serious sickness caused by the body getting too hot and not cooling down.

misting stations -- Places that spray fine water droplets to help people cool off.

extreme heat warning -- An official alert that the heat is dangerously high.

Background you need

The World Cup is the biggest soccer tournament, held every four years, bringing together teams from around the world. Heat has been a problem before: in 2014, Brazil introduced cooling breaks during matches. FIFA (the organization that runs global soccer) has since made water breaks a rule when temperatures are too high.

Break it down

WHO: Players at the 2026 World Cup, fans attending games, and FIFA officials.

WHAT: A powerful heat dome is pushing temperatures above 110°F, forcing FIFA to require two water breaks per half and allow five substitutions.

WHERE: Stadiums across the U.S. and Canada, especially Toronto, Kansas City, Dallas, Philadelphia, and others without full roofs.

WHY: Extreme heat can cause dangerous health problems like heat stroke, so FIFA is trying to protect players and fans.

Why it matters

Just like the World Cup players, you need to take water breaks and stay in the shade when you play outside on scorching days.

Test what you remember

1. What is a heat dome?
 - ☐ (A) A giant fan
 - ☐ (B) A bubble of super-hot air
 - ☐ (C) A cool breeze
 - ☐ (D) A rain cloud
2. How many mandatory water breaks does FIFA require per game?
 - ☐ (A) None
 - ☐ (B) One
 - ☐ (C) Two
 - ☐ (D) Three
3. What is the maximum number of times a player can be swapped out in a match?
 - ☐ (A) Three
 - ☐ (B) Four
 - ☐ (C) Five
 - ☐ (D) Six
4. Which cities have stadiums with roofs and air conditioning?
 - ☐ (A) Philadelphia and Kansas City
 - ☐ (B) Toronto and Dallas
 - ☐ (C) Atlanta and Houston
 - ☐ (D) Portugal and Croatia
5. What serious illness can heat cause?
 - ☐ (A) Heat stroke
 - ☐ (B) A cold
 - ☐ (C) A broken leg
 - ☐ (D) Allergies
6. What is the heat index in Kansas City expected to reach?
 - ☐ (A) 90°F
 - ☐ (B) 100°F
 - ☐ (C) 110°F
 - ☐ (D) 122°F

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: C 4: C 5: A 6: C

1. **Players:** Players are glad for water breaks and substitutions because heat stroke is dangerous, but constant stops can break their focus and rhythm.
2. **Fans at open stadiums:** Fans love the excitement, but sitting in 110°F heat for hours is exhausting and risky, so they rely on misting stations and shade.
3. **FIFA:** FIFA wants the tournament to be exciting and safe, but they must balance health rules with keeping the competition fair and on schedule.